

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

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To the Bahá'ís of the World

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1 August 2014

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Dearly loved Friends,

^{32.1} Over two years have elapsed since our announcement at

Rid.ván 2012 of projects to raise two national and five local

Houses of Worship, to be pursued in conjunction with the

construction in Santiago, Chile, of the last of the continental

Mashriqu'l-Adhkárs. These undertakings, inextricably linked to

³³ the development of community life now being fostered every-where through acts of devotion and service, are further steps

in the sublime task entrusted to humanity by Bahá'u'lláh to

³⁴ build Houses of Worship “throughout the lands in the name of Him Who is the Lord of all religions”—centers in which souls

may gather “harmoniously attuned one to another” to hear the

divine verses and to offer supplications, and from which “the

voices of praise may rise to the Kingdom” and the “fragrance

³⁵ of God” be diffused.

^{32.2} We are deeply moved by the response in every part of the

world to our call. Particularly in the nations and localities

33 recently designated for the construction of a House of Worship,

we have witnessed the friends' spontaneous expressions of

joy; their immediate and heartfelt commitment to lend their

34 share in carrying out the critical work at hand and to increase the dynamism of those activities integral to the emergence

of a Mashriqu'l-Adhkár within a population; their sacrificial

35 contributions of time, energy, and material resources, in a variety of forms; and their sustained efforts to awaken growing

contingents to the vision of those edifices dedicated wholly to

36 the remembrance of God that will be founded in their midst.

Indeed, the ready response of the community of the Greatest

37 Name augurs well for its ability to further these collective undertakings.

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39 FRAMEWORK FOR ACTION32.3 The National Spiritual Assemblies of the Democratic

Republic of the Congo and Papua New Guinea as well as those

of Cambodia, Colombia, India, Kenya, and Vanuatu, with the

close support of the Office of Temples and Sites created at the

Bahá'í World Centre in 2012, promptly moved forward with

40 the initial preparations. A committee was formed in each coun-try, entrusted with identifying, together with institutions and agencies at all levels of the community, means to promote wide-

spread participation and to channel the enthusiasm engendered

41 among the friends following the announcement of the projects.

Another practical step in these national and local projects

42 has been the selection of a suitable piece of land, one which is modest in size, strategically located, and easily accessible.

Four of the seven properties are now in hand. A construction

43 office for each project is being established to assist with the management of technical, financial, and legal issues. The work

involved in the opening stage has advanced through generous

contributions from the friends all over the world to the Temples

Fund. Universal and sacrificial support for this Fund will ensure

44 the steady progress of the next phases.

32.4 In four countries, the projects have reached the stage of

preparing a design for the Temple edifice. This begins with the

selection of potential architects and the formulation of an ar -

33 chitectural brief defining the requirements for the structure, and it ultimately results in a contract for the final design. Architects

34 are presented with the singular challenge of designing Temples “as perfect as is possible in the world of being” that harmonize

naturally with the local culture and the daily lives of those

35 who will gather to pray and meditate therein. The task calls for creativity and skill to combine beauty, grace, and dignity with

modesty, functionality, and economy. A number of architects

from near and far have gladly offered their services, and

while such contributions are of course welcomed, National

36 Assemblies are giving due regard to the value of engaging architects who are well acquainted with the area where the

37 edifice will be built.

32.5 The erection of the continental House of Worship for

33 South America is moving towards its completion in Chile. The steel-frame superstructure has been almost entirely installed, the

34 placement of the interior translucent stone panels is under way,

and the landscaping and the construction of auxiliary facilities

35 are progressing according to schedule. The friends in Santiago,

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diligently striving to prepare the surrounding population for

the emergence of the House of Worship; increasing numbers

are participating in the community-building endeavors, and a

stream of visitors are being welcomed to the Temple site for

³⁷ prayer and discussion on the practical and spiritual dimensions of the enterprise. Measures are currently being put in place in

that country in anticipation of the many demands that are sure

³⁸ to arise once the Temple is inaugurated in 2016.

^{32.6} As the friends worldwide rejoice in these heartening ad-

vances, their energies remain focused on the processes gaining

strength in cluster after cluster. In this, they have not failed

to appreciate the dynamic interaction between worship and en-

deavors to uplift the spiritual, social, and material conditions of

³³ society. May all those who are thus laboring in towns and cities, neighborhoods and villages, derive insights from the exertions

made to raise up the first two Houses of Worship at the turn of

³⁴ the twentieth century, in the East and then in the West.

^{32.7} In the city of 'Ishqábád, a devoted band of believers who

settled from Persia, and who, for a time, found peace and tran-

quillity in Turkistán, bent their energies towards the creation

of a pattern of life that would reflect the exalted spiritual and

social principles enshrined in the Revelation of Bahá'u'lláh. In

³³ a span of a few decades, this group, originally consisting of a handful of families, was joined there by others and grew to a

few thousand believers. This community, fortified by ties of

³⁴ camaraderie and animated by unity of purpose and a spirit of faithfulness, was enabled to reach a high degree of cohesiveness

and development, for which it gained renown throughout the

Bahá'í world. These friends, guided by their understanding of

the divine Teachings, and within the bounds of the religious

³⁵ freedom they were accorded, toiled to create the conditions that would lead to the founding of a Mashriqu'l-Adhkár,

³⁶ that "crowning institution in every Bahá'í community." On a befitting tract of land in the center of the city that had been obtained some years before with the consent of the Blessed Beauty

Himself, facilities were built for communal well-being—a meet -

³⁷ ing hall, schools for children, a hostel for visitors, and a small clinic, among others. A sign of the notable achievements of the

³⁸ Bahá'ís in 'Ishqábád, who in those productive years became distinguished for their prosperity, magnanimity, and intellectual

and cultural attainments, was their attention to ensuring that

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⁴⁰ FRAMEWORK FOR ACTION All Bahá'í children and youth were literate in a society with

rampant illiteracy, especially among girls. Within such an envi-

ronment of unified endeavor and progress, and fostered at every

stage of development by 'Abdu'l-Bahá, a magnificent House of

Worship emerged—the most prominent edifice in the area. For

⁴¹ over twenty years, the friends experienced the heavenly joy of having realized their lofty aim: the establishment of a focal

point of worship, a nerve center of community life, a place

⁴² where souls gathered at daybreak for humble invocation and communion before flowing out of its doors to engage in their

daily pursuits. While the forces of irreligion eventually swept

through the region and thwarted hopes, the brief appearance of

a Mashriqu'l-Adhkár in 'Ishqábád is an enduring testament to

⁴³ the volition and effort of a body of believers who established a rich pattern of life deriving its impetus from the power of the

⁴⁴ Creative Word.

^{32.8} In the Western Hemisphere, shortly after work commenced

³³ on the House of Worship in 'Ishqábád, the members of the nascent Bahá'í community in North America were galvanized

to demonstrate their faith and devotion by constructing a

Temple of their own, and they wrote in 1903 to seek the

³⁴ Master's consent. From that moment, the Mashriqu'l-Adhkár became inseparably intertwined with the fate of those dedicated

servants of Bahá'u'lláh. While progress on this complex project

³⁵ was obstructed over decades by the effects of two world wars and a widespread economic depression, each stage in

its development was intimately tied to the expansion of the

community and the unfoldment of its administration. On the

same day as the interment of the sacred remains of the Báb on

³⁶ Mount Carmel in March 1909, delegates gathered to establish the Bahá'í Temple Unity, a national organization whose elected

Board became the nucleus of the far-flung local communities of

³⁷ the continent. This development soon gave rise to the formation of the National Spiritual Assembly of the Bahá'ís of the United

States and Canada. 'Abdu'l-Bahá Himself laid the cornerstone

of the building during His travels to North America, endowing

the Mother Temple of the West with tremendous spiritual po-

³⁸ tentialities. And contributions for this historic enterprise flowed from Bahá'í centers in Africa, Asia, Europe, Latin America,

and the Pacific—a demonstration of the solidarity and sacrifice

³⁹ of the Bahá'ís of the East and West.

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thoughts on God and occupy themselves each day with His

remembrance, ceaselessly exerting effort in His Name, let

them draw inspiration from these stirring words addressed by

'Abdu'l-Bahá to a believer who was devoted to building the first

⁴¹ House of Worship, raised under His close and loving direction:

^{32.10} Hasten now to 'Ishqábád, in the utmost detachment and aflame with the fire of attraction, and convey to the friends

of God ardent greetings from 'Abdu'l-Bahá. Kiss thou each

one's face and express this servant's deep and sincere af-

fection to all. Do thou on behalf of 'Abdu'l-Bahá move the

³³ earth, carry the mortar, and haul the stones for the building of the Mashriqu'l-Adhkár so that the rapture of this service

may bring joy and gladness to the Center of Servitude. That

³⁴ Mashriqu'l-Adhkár is the first visible and manifest establishment of the Lord. Therefore, it is this servant's hope that

each and every virtuous and righteous soul will sacrifice

his all, evince great happiness and exultation, and rejoice

in carrying the earth and mortar so that this Divine Edifice

³⁵ may be raised, the Cause of God may spread, and in every corner of the world the friends may arise with the utmost

resolve to accomplish this great task. Were 'Abdu'l-Bahá

³⁶ not imprisoned and were there not obstacles in his path, he himself would assuredly hasten to 'Ishqábád and carry the

earth for the building of the Mashriqu'l-Adhkár with the

utmost joy and gladness. It behoveth the friends now to

arise with this intention in mind and serve in my place so

³⁷ that in a short time this Edifice may be revealed to all eyes, the loved ones of God may engage in making mention of the

Abhá Beauty, the melodies of the Mashriqu'l-Adhkár may

rise at dawning to the Concourse on high, and the songs

of the nightingales of God may bring joy and ecstasy to

³⁸ the denizens of the All-Glorious Realm. Thus will the hearts rejoice, the souls delight in joyful tidings, and the minds be

illuminated. This is the highest hope of the sincere ones; this

³⁹ is the dearest wish of them that are nigh unto God.

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]